

CHAO FA

THE TRAIL · A COOPERATIVE JOURNEY TO THE MEKONG

RULEBOOK

1–6 PLAYERS AGES 12+ 60–120 MINUTES

This game is dedicated to all the men and women who served in the Vietnam War; to the Hmong who served and were killed; to those who died in the jungles of Laos and those who are still there; to the CIA, to General Vang Pao, and to everyone who brought attention to this tragic chapter of history.

SECOND EDITION · THE TRAIL · NO DICE: THE FORTUNE DECK AND THE PATROL TABLE (2026)

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How to use these books

This **Rulebook** is everything you need to play: read it once, then keep the player aids on the table. The **Companion** lists every card and holds the two endings, the history and the real voices behind the game; open it when a card tells you to, and at the end of the game. The **Endings booklet** has what became of each villager, one numbered ending for every fate: look up the villager and the number (for example Mai 7) when the game is over. There are no dice: everything you need is in the box.

THE STORY

Your nightmare has only begun



Leaving the village, spring 1975.

The year is 1975. Saigon fell on April 30 and the Vietnam War is ending. You are Hmong, a people who secretly supported the United States and its CIA-backed army. You are a countryless nation: a people with no country of your own, and after this spring not even the hills you were born in. As the Americans leave and the communists take the capital, you and your village flee into the jungle, afraid of being punished for siding with the enemy.

Together you must walk south through the hills, the jungle and the lowlands, search for what you need to live, recover the nine squares of a story cloth, each won with a key (a contact, a route, a signal) on the way to a safe crossing, and cross the Mekong into Thailand. You have five years. Every fight makes you stronger, but it makes the enemy stronger too, and the persecution of the Chao Fa grows with each season.

Chao Fa is based on real-life stories. The villagers are invented, but what happens to them, the endings you read and the voices you hear at the end are drawn from the accounts of Hmong families who lived through these years.

Chao Fa is a cooperative game. Everyone at the table plays one family. You win together when someone reaches the Thai bank, and you lose together when no one does. It is a hard game by design: most who set out do not reach Thailand, and whole families almost never arrive together. Play it like the people it is about: carefully, together, and without giving up.

A note on history

"Chao Fa" (Lao, "Lords of the Sky"; Hmong *Cob Fab*) is the name given to the Hmong resistance that held out around Phou Bia after 1975. The characters in this game are ordinary villagers, not real people. The endings, the Voice cards and the history chapters in the **Companion** book tell what really happened, year by year, based on true stories; disputed figures (casualty counts, chemical attacks) are shown as ranges and say that they are disputed.

IN THE BOX

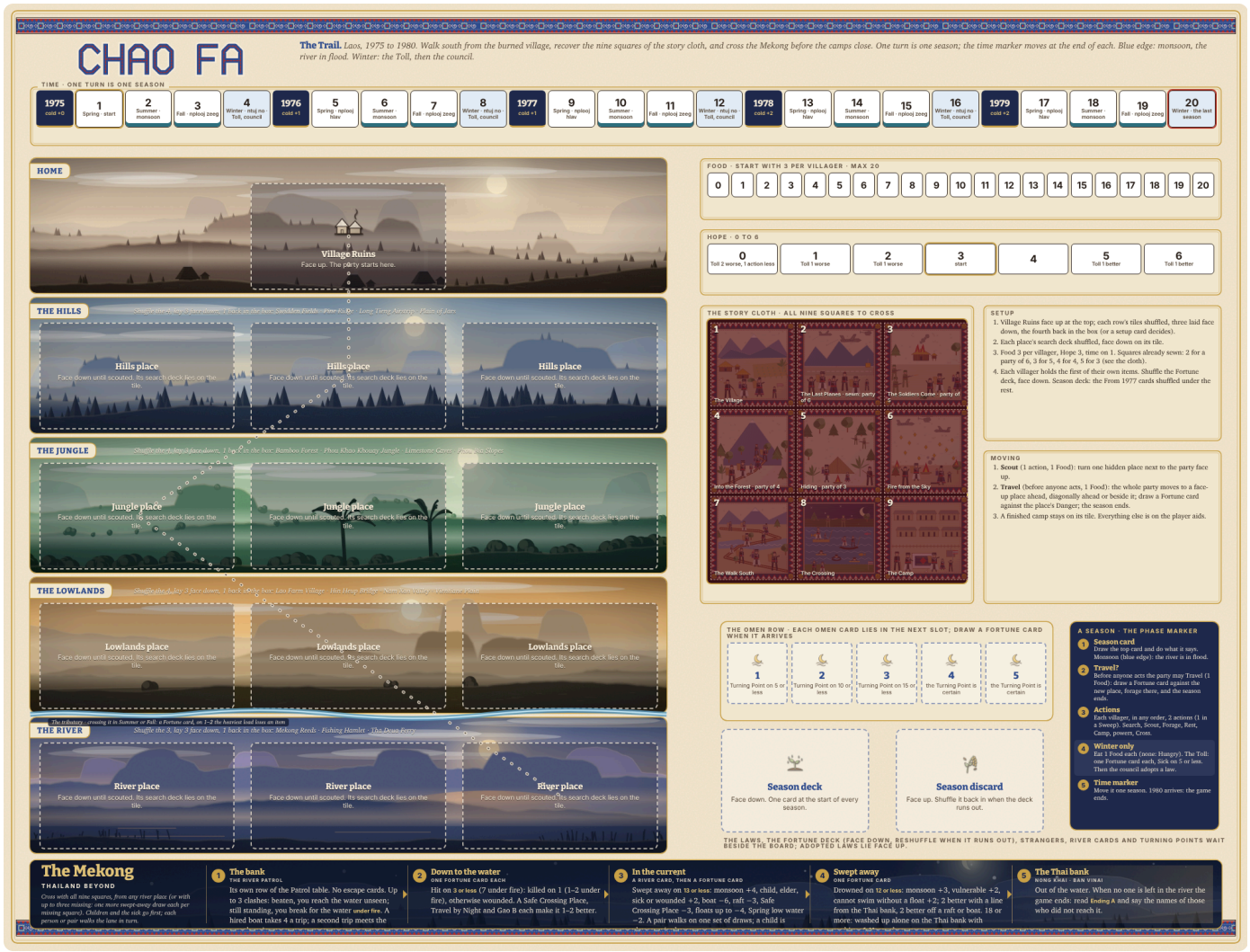
Components

COMPONENT	QTY	WHAT IT IS
Villager cards	16	8 men, 8 women; each has HP, ATK and DEF (6 points in all, the same on both sides). Side A has a power used once a season; Side B has a trait that is always on.
Place tiles	16	The home village, then four rows of three places laid from a pool of four: the hills (with the Plain of Jars), the jungle (with the slopes of Phou Bia), the lowlands (with the Vientiane plain) and the river. Each tile shows its danger number, the grade of fight there and what can be foraged there; its back is the place picked clean.
Setup, scenario and symbol key cards	3 + 3	Two historical trails that lay the tiles in a fixed order, the Late Crossing scenario, and three cards that explain every mark on the cards.
Search cards	249	One small deck per place, with that place's picture on the back: the items, food, shelter, remedies, clues, keys and dangers you would really find there.
Items (among the search cards)	88	38 from the original design (32 belong to a villager, 6 are legendary) and the found items such as rice pots, rafts, quinine and the boatman's silver. Every item card says where it is found and why.
Keys (among the search cards)	37	Contacts, routes, times and signals, each guarded. Win one and you recover the next square of the story cloth: 1 in the village and more in each row toward the river.
Season cards	85	Patrols, ambushes, fog, food, omens, time slipping by, history and moral dilemmas. One is drawn at the start of every season.
Stranger cards	13	People you meet when you Seek Help: a trader, a deserter, a txiv neeb, lost children. Each is a choice of two.
Turning Point cards	6	Drawn at random when the omens come true. Each one changes the rest of the game.
Law cards	6	At the end of each year the council draws 2 and may adopt one.
Story cloth squares	9	Square cards that make one 3 × 3 story cloth (*paj ntaub dab neeg*), each showing one stage of the escape. All nine are needed to cross the Mekong. A cloth mat shows where they lie.
River cards	21	Drawn one per person at the crossing: slack water, a searchlight, a drifting log, the machine gun. 3 of them only in the monsoon.
Ending and Voice cards	2 + 14	When the game ends, read Ending A (someone crossed) or Ending B (no one crossed), then draw a Voice card of that ending: the true story of a real person.
Board	1	Four sheets joined into one 21 × 16 in board: spaces for the map and the search decks, the Mekong, the Time track (seasons 1–20 with the cold of each year), Food 0–20, Hope 0–6, the story cloth, the season phase track, spaces for the Season deck, and the Mekong crossing lane along the bottom.
Standees and markers	—	A standee for each villager, the party pawn, markers for time, Food, Hope, the phase of the season, camps, Sick, Wound, Bamboo Armor, Ambush (dug in), fallen squares, guards, alarms, caches, planted fields and the power discs. Player aids, one per seat. The Fortune deck: 20 cards numbered 1 to 20, the game's only chance. No dice.
Fight tracker and Patrol card	2 + 2	A tall card that holds a fight from start to finish (the soldiers' number, three clash rows for the Fortune cards, the damage strip) and a two-faced Patrol table card, one year block on each face.
Family boards	6	One per seat: the villager card lies in its window; the HP track, the Sick, Hungry and power boxes and a drawn slot for each item the villager carries.
Deck dividers, bag labels and insert	—	A tabbed divider for every search deck and every other deck, labels for the token bags, and the box insert diagram, so the game is on the table in five minutes.

Trail diary and family record	2 pads	A sheet to keep one line a season and the Food and Hope of each Winter, and a sheet to record the family's fate and the number of each villager's ending.
The First Winter	1	A printed first game: four pages that deal a fixed start and walk one family through its first year, card by card, with a short rule each time one is needed.



The cards: a villager, a search card, a Season card, a square of the story cloth and an ending.



The board, assembled from four Letter sheets: the map and its search decks on the left, time, Food, Hope, the story cloth and the phase track on the right, the five stations of the Mekong along the bottom.

Reading a card

Every card has the same parts, so once you can read one you can read them all. The **strip** across the top names the deck (the place a search card comes from, Season, Stranger, River, Villager). The **title plate** gives the card's name; under it the **effect box** says what the card does in play, and the smaller text says where it is found and why. **Stats** are shown as pips: ●●○○○ is 2 HP, ♦♦♦◇◇ is 3 ATK, ⛊⛉⛉⛉⛉ is 1 DEF. Item cards show their **slot** (hands, body, head, pack or shared) in the corner. Every card carries its deck and number (for example "Village 3/16") so a missing card is easy to find.

A villager card has two sides. **Side A** gives a power the villager uses once a season; **Side B** gives a trait that is always on. Both sides have the same HP, ATK and DEF, so the choice is how you want to play that person. You choose the side when you set up and keep it for the whole game.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Setup



TIME · 1 SEASON EACH

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20

FOOD · 3 × VILLAGERS

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20

HOPE

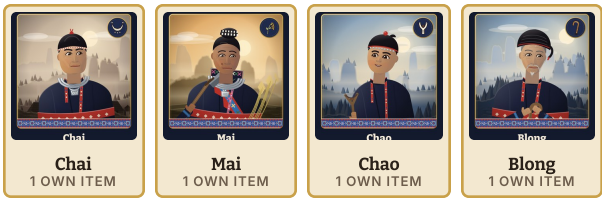
0	1	2	3	4	5	6

STORY CLOTH · SQUARES SEWN

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9

Season deck · Laws · Strangers · Turning Points · River

Decks face down beside the board; the Fortune deck within reach.



A party of four: Chai, Mai, Chao and Blong, each with the first of their own items and a standee on the Village Ruins. Food 12, Hope 3, squares 1 to 4 already sewn.

1. **The map.** Put the Village Ruins at the top. Each row below it has **four** tiles: shuffle them, lay **three** face down and put the fourth back in the box, so that four rows of three lie below the village with the river row at the bottom, next to the Mekong (the river row has only three). Or take a **setup card** and lay the tiles it names, in its order: the Phou Bia Trail or the Western Trail. Turn the village face up and put the party pawn on it.

2. **Search decks.** Shuffle each place's search deck and put it face down beside its tile.

3. **Villagers.** The party is always **3 to 6 villagers**: one player runs 3, two players run 2 each (or 3 each for a party of 6), and 3 to 6 players take one each. Each player chooses which side of their card faces up, A or B, and keeps it for the game. The number of villagers at the start is **X**. Everyone starts with **one item**: the first of their own items (their name is on the card), the one thing they carried out of the village. Take it out of its search deck. Put each villager's standee on the village.

4. **The story cloth.** A small family starts with the first squares already sewn: a party of 6 starts with squares 1 and 2, 5 with squares 1 to 3, 4 with squares 1 to 4, and 3 with squares 1 to 5. Lay those squares on the cloth mat.

5. **Tracks.** Set Food to 3 × X (a party of 4 starts with 12), Hope to 3, and the time marker on season 1, Spring 1975.

6. **Decks.** Shuffle the Fortune deck. Shuffle the Season deck in **two stacks**: the cards marked *From 1977* and later are shuffled and put under the rest, so the war arrives in its own time. Shuffle the Law cards, the Stranger cards, the Turning Point cards and the River deck (set its 3 monsoon cards aside until a Summer or Fall crossing) and put them face down beside the board. Keep the Ending and Voice cards and the Companion book for the end of the game.

Playing alone? One player runs 3 villagers and makes every decision. Two players run 2 each. The game plays the same way at every count; only the number of hands changes. Each player speaks for their own villager: in a dilemma or at a Stranger, the one whose villager is named has the last word.

Three golden rules

1. A card beats the rulebook.
2. A specific rule beats a general one.
3. When the table cannot agree, the elders decide: the player of the oldest villager.

A ladder of first games

First: The First Winter, the printed first game (or the app's Learn to play) with Chai, Mai, Chao and Blong. **Second:** the same four on the Short Trail, your own decisions. **Third:** the full Trail with a party of four or five; add Tou, then Kong. **After that:** the villagers with the hardest powers (Ka, Pa, Cheng, Lee), a setup card, Side B, and the Late Crossing scenario when a game has ended with the family still in Laos.

THE GOAL

Winning and losing

You all win together, and you all lose together.

Ending A: Across the Mekong

At least one person reaches Thailand. To cross you need **all nine squares of the story cloth**, and then to survive the river: the River Patrol on the bank, and three checks in the water for each person. Count who made it, and name the ones who did not.

Ending B: The ones who stayed

No one crosses: every villager dies (in a fight, of hunger, of sickness or in the river) or is taken prisoner, or Winter 1979 (season 20) ends with the party still in the hills.

Either way the game ends with the ending card read aloud, then a Voice card, then what became of each villager, and the dedication. The ending is part of the game: do not skip it.

The five years

The game lasts at most **20 seasons**, Spring 1975 to Winter 1979, one season per round. Time only moves forward. Each Winter is colder than the last, which makes the Toll worse, and each year the army hunts harder: the soldiers' numbers grow with the year. The sooner you reach the river with the cloth complete, the better your chances; but a family that rushes arrives hungry, hurt and empty-handed.

PLAYING

A season



Hiding in the jungle in the rainy season.

Chao Fa is about looking: every place on the map has its own deck, and what you find depends on where you are. One season is one round of the table, in three steps. The **phase track** on the board walks through them: move the phase marker down it as you go, and back to the top when the time marker moves.

1. **Season card.** Draw the top Season card and resolve it. A patrol is a fight wherever you are; food goes to the store; DEF and HP cards go to a player's hand; a **Time card** costs you time: *The Army Advances* loses the season (move the time marker forward 1; in Winter, hide instead), *A Sweep Through the Hills* leaves everyone 1 action and no Travel, and *A Quiet Spell* makes this season's Travel and foraging safe. Time never moves back. A **history card** drawn before its year is set aside and another is drawn. A **Dilemma** must be answered by the whole party before anyone acts. **Omens** stay face up (see Turning Points).

2. **Actions.** Each villager takes **2 actions**, or **1** if Sick. If Hope is 0, everyone has one action less (never fewer than 1). Go round the table; a villager may take both actions at once or split them with others' turns, as the party prefers. **Travel is different:** the whole party moves, and only before anyone has acted this season (see Actions).
3. **End of season.** Sick people nobody nursed draw for fever. In **Winter**, everyone eats 1 Food, then the Toll, then the council (see Winter). Move the time marker forward one season.

Hard work eats

Search, **Scout** and **Build a camp** each cost **1 Food** from the store, and a **journey** (Travel) eats 1 Food after the forage you gather on the way. With no Food left, the worker still goes, but takes a wound (not if that wound would kill them). Searches you get for free (spoils after a fight, a power's free searches) cost nothing; so do Forage, Rest, Trade and the rest. Every place with any forage this season gives **1 more** than its tile shows. The rest of the year, nobody eats at the end of the season: you eat by working.

Seasons and the monsoon

Spring · Summer · Fall · Winter. Summer and Fall are the **monsoon**: the Mekong is in flood, which makes every crossing check 4 worse and adds the 3 flood cards to the River deck. Each Spring, everyone who ate heals 1 wound. Each place's tile shows how much Food it gives in each season.

For example

Summer 1976, the Phou Khao Khouay Jungle. The Season card is *Fog in the Valley*: it goes to Tou's hand as an escape card. Nobody travels. Chai searches (1 Food) and draws a Hard danger; the party fights (see Fights) and wins, then searches twice in safety: Herbs and a Guide. Mai forages: the jungle gives 1 in Summer, and her draw of 9 is above 3, so no one spots her. Chao scouts the next row (1 Food). Blong rests and heals a wound. Move the time marker to Fall.

When your villager dies

You keep playing. Once a season, after the living have taken their actions, the players whose villagers have died choose **one living villager to take 1 more action**, and they play it (any action but Travel). With several fallen players it is still 1 action a season: decide it together. You still read the cards, draw the Fortune cards and vote at the council.

The Fortune deck (*hmoov*)

There are no dice in Chao Fa. Wherever chance is needed, **draw the top card of the Fortune deck**: 20 cards numbered 1 to 20, shuffled face down beside the board. Read the number against the rule (a Danger number, the Toll, a fever, a crossing check) and put the card on the Fortune discard; when the deck runs out, shuffle the discard and go on. Because every number comes out once before any comes again, a run of bad cards means better ones are coming, and a table that counts can feel the deck turning. Each card also carries a Hmong saying for the moment, and the low and high cards swing a clash in a fight (see Fights).

PLAYING

Actions

Each villager takes two actions a season (one if Sick, one less for everyone at Hope 0). An action is one of these. Travel is the only action the whole party takes together.

ACTION · COST	WHAT HAPPENS
Search 1 Food	Draw the top card of this place's search deck, read it aloud and resolve it. Items go to anyone in the party, but a villager's own item (their name is on the card) goes to them if they are alive. Food goes to the store. Shelter and remedy cards go to your hand. A Danger card is a fight now. Clues stay with the tile. A key starts a key encounter (see The story cloth). **Noise:** if this place has been searched before, draw a Fortune card first: on the number of earlier searches here or less, soldiers come to look. Fight at the place's level, with no spoils, then search.
Scout 1 Food	Turn face up one hidden tile next to the party (ahead, diagonally ahead, or to the side). You may now Travel there in a later season.
Travel 1 Food, the whole season	The whole party moves to a face-up tile next to it: ahead, diagonally ahead, or to the side. Draw a Fortune card: on the tile's danger number or less (3 better with a Guide, 2 better with Lao Clothes or a Forged Travel Pass, better with certain laws), a patrol or animal finds you and you fight, as an **ambush**. You gather the tile's forage along the way. **Travel only before anyone takes an action that season**: travelling uses the whole season, and the season ends when you arrive.
Forage free	Gain the Food shown on the tile for this season, plus 1 (some tools add more). Draw a Fortune card: on 1 to 3 you are spotted and fight, as an ambush.
Rest or nurse free	Nurse a sick person: the fever always breaks if Kong (Side B) is in the party, or if Lee or Pa (Side B) is the one nursing; with medicine in the party (Medicine Box, Herbs, Bandages, Scalpel or Quinine) it breaks on a Fortune card of 6 or more; otherwise on 11 or more. Or rest: heal 1 wound (one more at a finished camp).
Build a camp 1 Food per action	Two actions finish a hidden camp on this tile (they need not be the same villager's, or the same season's). A finished camp makes the Winter Toll 1 better and resting heal 1 more. Put a Camp marker on the tile; it stays there.
Power, play a card, give an item see the card	Use your Side A power if it is an action (once a season; see The villagers); play a DEF or HP card from your hand for the next fight; or hand an item to someone in the party. (Giving an item is free when the item is found.)

When you cannot move

These give the party something worth doing while it waits out a season, searches a place out, or hides. Each has a cost or a risk.

ACTION · LIMIT	WHAT HAPPENS
Lay an ambush once at each place	Dig firing positions: the next fight here, the party fires first (the soldiers deal no damage in the first clash). Put an Ambush marker on the tile.
Cover tracks once a season	Brush out the trail: searching this place again counts 2 fewer earlier searches for noise.
Trade where people live	At a Lao village, the hamlet, the road or the ferry: give up any item for 3 Food. Draw a Fortune card: on 1 to 3 someone who saw the trade informs, and you fight at the place's level.
Share a meal once a season, 2 Food	Spend 2 Food: Hope +1.
Seek help once a season	Draw a Stranger card and choose one of its two answers as a party. Shuffle the discards when the deck runs out.

Carrying things

Each villager has **2 hands**, **1 body**, **1 head** and **3 pack** slots. A rifle, bow or spear takes both hands; a knife, machete, axe or cane takes one. Animals, boats, raft wood and food caches belong to the whole party and take no slot. When someone has too much, hand an item to someone with room (1 action on your turn, or free when it is found) or leave it behind for good; you may also leave an item at any time. Each item card shows its slot. Any villager can carry any item: a villager's own item gives them the larger bonus, anyone else the smaller one; legendary items work the same for everyone and each has a power; found items have their effect printed on the card.

Clans, fields, caches and animals

Clans and kin

Each villager card names a clan. Three of the Strangers belong to a clan too: when a Stranger shares a clan with any living villager, they are kin, and the Stranger's better answer costs the party nothing (no Food, no item). Clan kinship obliged a Hmong family to shelter a clansman on the road, even one never met, and families on the trail looked for their clan first.

Carrying a child

When the party travels, an adult with a free hand carries a child (Chao or Gao) on their back. The child takes no Danger hit that season; in a fight that season the carrier has one hand (ATK −1) and the child cannot be hit. Children were carried in a cloth sling for the whole walk.

Hidden fields

In **Spring**, at the Swidden Fields, the Stream or the Vientiane plain, the party may **plant** (1 action, 1 Food): put a Planted Field token on the tile. If the party is still there in **Fall** and no fight has happened on that tile since, the field is harvested: **+4 Food**. A fight tramples it. Families who hid for years in the hills lived on fields like these, planted in a clearing and visited at night.

Caches

Anything the party cannot carry, or chooses to leave, goes into a **cache** on the tile (a Cache token): the items stay there and are picked up when the party returns, by anyone with room. A horse that cannot enter the caves waits in the cache of the tile it was left on.

Animals

A Horse or a Water Buffalo gives every villager **one more pack slot** while it is with the party. An animal may be **slaughtered** (1 action) for **4 Food** and −1 Hope. Animals cannot go into the Limestone Caves and are left on the bank at the river.

Money, disguise and the used side

Silver, French coins, Thai baht and a ball of opium are **money**: any of them pays a Boatman's seat, a key's price, a trade or a shakedown. Opium also eases a fever: spend it and a Sick villager is not Sick for one Winter Toll. Lao Clothes, a Forged Travel Pass, a Lao Identity Card and the Translator are **disguise pieces**; two in the party and no one looks twice at a Guarded or Price key. Quinine, Bandages, Army Rations, Joss Paper, Incense and the Field Dressing are turned **face down when used** instead of discarded, so the family board shows what the party once had.

Three more places

Each row below the village now has four tiles in its pool, and three are laid. The three newcomers:



Plain of Jars (The hills) Open grassland around the great stone jars, cratered and littered with old bombs. Fast to cross and easy to see across. The ground was bombed more than any other in the war, and the small bombs are still in the grass.



Phou Bia Slopes (The jungle) The high slopes of the biggest mountain in Laos, cold, steep and full of hiding families. The Chao Fa held the mountain, and whole villages hid with them. From 1977 the army came for it with artillery, from posts like Muang Cha below the slopes.



Vientiane Plain (The lowlands) Rice paddies, market towns and the road into the capital, a day from the river. The best trade before the river, and the most soldiers. Everyone on the plain is asked for papers.

The slopes of Phou Bia are a medium place until the army comes for the mountain: **from 1977** its Danger is 6 and its fights are Hard. Its deck holds the Chao Fa themselves (*The Chao Fa Take You In*: +3 ATK for the next three fights), and the Pahawh mark on those cards is the script the movement wrote in. The Plain of Jars is fast and open and still full of old bombs (*Old bombs* cards: a Fortune card each, wounds on 1 or 2). The Vientiane plain is the best trade before the river

(an item for 4 Food) and the most soldiers; everyone there is asked for papers. The Long Tieng Airstrip is the old headquarters the planes left in May 1975; the Hin Heup Bridge is the Route 13 checkpoint where soldiers fired on the families walking to Vientiane that same spring; the Phou Khao Khouay Jungle, the Nam Xan Valley and the Tha Deua Ferry are the forest, the stream and the crossing that real families used; the Limestone Caves remember Tham Piu.

Every place on the board is a real one from the flight of 1975 to 1979, or stands for the kind of place families passed through: the Swidden Fields, the Pine Ridge, the Bamboo Forest, the Lao Farm Village and the Fishing Hamlet have no single name because there were hundreds of each.

A place picked clean

When a place's search deck runs out, **turn the tile over**: it is picked clean. No forage there, no search, and its Danger is 1 better, because nobody is there any more.

The year turns

The burning season (a Spring card): the swidden fires fill the hills with smoke; the party is harder to find (Danger 2 better) and there is nothing to forage in the ash. **The New Year in hiding**: at the first Winter meal, if the family can spare 2 Food and Hope is not full, they keep the New Year with a quiet meal and Hope rises 1. Some dilemmas **come back**: a choice made badly returns three cards down the Season deck as a memory.

SURVIVING

Hunger, sickness, Hope and the Winter



Winter in the hills: the Toll.

Hunger, wounds and sickness

Each person carries their own state. Each Winter everyone eats 1 Food, and hard work eats along the way (see A season); each Food you are short at the Winter meal is a wound to someone who has not gone hungry yet, and that person is **hungry** until the next meal. **Wounds** (−1 HP each) stay until healed by resting or a power; each Spring, everyone who ate heals 1 more. A villager whose wounds reach their HP dies. **Sick** people act once a season, must be nursed each season or draw for fever at the end of it (death on a Fortune card of 1 to 5), and die if the Winter Toll takes them again.

Hope

Hope runs from 0 to 6 and starts at 3. Each death costs 1 Hope (unless a funeral is held with the Qeej, Joss Paper or Incense, or the Proper Funerals law is in force); a hungry Winter costs 1; dilemmas and strangers raise or lower it; sharing a meal raises it. **Hope 0:** everyone has one action less and the Toll is 2 worse. **Hope 1–2:** the Toll is 1 worse. **Hope 5–6:** the Toll is 1 better. At the river, Hope buys a second chance (see The river).

Winter: the Toll

The cold gets worse every year: +0 in 1975, +1 in 1976 and 1977, +2 in 1978 and 1979. At the end of each Winter, after eating, every villager draws a Fortune card and falls **Sick** on 5 or less, adjusted:

WINTER TOLL	CHANGE
Child, elder, wounded or already sick	+1
Each Food short this year (max +3)	+1
Cold of the year	+0 to +2
Hope 0 / Hope 1–2 / Hope 5–6	+2 / +1 / −1

Healer in the party (Kong on Side B, or medicine)	−1
Finished camp on this tile	−1
Holder of a Blanket, Parachute, Poncho, Water Gourd, Mosquito Net or Clay Jar (−1), or Quinine (−2); at most −2 per person	−1 or −2

A villager who is already Sick and fails the Toll dies. Then the time marker moves to the next Spring.

The council and the laws

After the Toll the families hold a council. Draw **2 laws** the party has not adopted (3 with Chai on Side B); the party may adopt **one** of them and shuffles the other back. Adopted laws lie face up beside the board. Laws cannot be undone; every one has a cost.

LAW	EFFECT AND COST
Council of Elders	The elders decide together. At every year end, +1 Hope, but 1 Food is cooked for the council.
Travel by Night	Every Danger draw when the party moves is 2 better, but each Forage finds 1 less Food.
Proper Funerals	Deaths cost no Hope, but each burial uses 1 Food for the funeral meal.
Everyone Nurses the Sick	Every Rest heals 1 extra wound or cures Sickness on any card, but each cure uses 1 Food for broth.
Strict Rations	In Spring and Summer only half the party (rounded up) eats. -1 Hope at every year end while anyone is hungry.
Travel Light	Each person keeps at most 3 items (discard the rest now). Every Danger draw is 2 better.

FIGHTING

Fights

A fight happens when you draw a Danger or patrol card, when a forager is spotted, when you are found travelling, at a key, and at the river. It has three steps: **read the soldiers' number, clash up to three times, count the cost**. There are no dice and nothing to add or multiply: the Patrol table gives the soldiers' number, and a Fortune card decides each clash.

1 · Read the soldiers' number

Lay the **fight tracker** card between you. **Your party:** add together the HP (less wounds), ATK and DEF of every living villager, their items, and any DEF or HP cards played for this fight; write them in its three boxes or lay tokens there.

The soldiers have one number, and it is their ATK, their DEF and their HP. Find it on the **Patrol table**: the row is the fight (Easy, Medium, Hard, Deadly, or the River Patrol), the column is how many of you are living, and the block is the year on the time track. The army hunts a big group harder, a small one is easier to miss, and from 1977 the hunt doubles. Put the **brass marker** on that number on the tracker's upper strip; the Patrol card beside it shows the same table, one year on each face.

	LIVING VILLAGERS, 1975 AND 1976						LIVING VILLAGERS, 1977 TO 1979					
THE FIGHT	1	2	3	4	5	6	1	2	3	4	5	6
Easy	1	1	2	4	6	9	1	3	5	9	13	19
Medium	1	2	3	5	7	10	2	4	6	10	14	20
Hard	5	6	7	9	11	14	6	8	10	14	18	24
Deadly	8	9	10	12	14	17	9	11	13	17	21	27
River Patrol	8	9	10	12	14	14	9	11	13	17	21	21

A party of 4 meeting a Hard patrol in 1977: the Hard row, the column for 4, the 1977 block: **14** ATK, DEF and HP. The River Patrol counts at most 5 people, so its last two columns are the same. On the Gentle level take 3 off every number; on Merciless add 3.

2 · Clash, up to three times

Each clash, first **draw a Fortune card** into the next slot on the tracker and do what it says: on **1 to 4** the soldiers' aim is true, +2 ATK for them this clash; on **17 to 20** the villagers find their mark, +2 ATK for you; anything else is an even clash. Then both sides strike at once. **You deal your ATK minus the soldiers' number. They deal their number minus your DEF, and always at least 1**, because gunfire gets through. The party chooses who takes the wounds; Armor stops them first. A fallen villager's ATK and DEF leave the party at once, and their items go to the survivors (unless they were taken prisoner, below). Move the **second marker** up the tracker's lower strip as you deal damage: the soldiers fall when it reaches the brass marker. After **three clashes**, if they still stand, the party breaks away with its wounds. (At the river, see The River Patrol.)

What changes a fight

- **Ambush.** When the party is **found** while travelling, **spotted** while foraging, or draws an **Ambush** card, the soldiers fire first: the party deals no damage in the first clash. A party that has laid an ambush where it stands fires first instead, and the soldiers deal nothing in the first clash.
- **Armor.** Helmets, vests, the padded jacket, the rattan shield and Bamboo Armor have **Armor**. In each fight, a villager's Armor stops that much of the damage that would go to them before it reaches HP. Put damage on armored villagers first: they stand in front.
- **Slipping away.** When soldiers find you (never the River Patrol), you may discard an **escape card** (A Hidden Path, Fog on the River, A Friendly Warning and others in the search decks, or Fog in the Valley from the Season deck) and there is no fight at all. Tou (Side A) may try to talk the party past first; Gao (Side A) can hush a noise or a spotting before it becomes a fight.
- **Prisoners.** When a villager falls in a fight (never in the river), draw a Fortune card: on **1 to 10** they were killed; on **11 to 20** they are taken prisoner, sent to a camp for "seminar" (Ending 4). Either way they leave the game and everything they

carried is lost with them. Far more Hmong were captured than killed in fights; the prisoner's story is the common one.

- **Break away.** After the first or second clash the party may **drop its loads and run**: discard one item per living villager (each chooses which), take no hit this clash, and the fight ends with nothing gained. Loads were what families dropped when they were fired on.
- **Shakedown.** An **Easy** fight is village militia, as often after rice and silver as after prisoners: instead of fighting, hand over **2 Food or one money item** (silver, coins, baht or opium) and walk on.
- **Loud weapons and the alarm.** Rifles, carbines, shotguns and the flintlock are **loud**; bows, crossbows, knives and spears are **quiet**. After a fight in which any loud weapon was used, put an **Alarm** token on the place: the next fight there is one row of the Patrol table harder, and the token is removed. A party armed only with quiet weapons raises no alarm, and a hunter (Sheng on Side B) with a quiet weapon fires first. A fight in a Lao village, the hamlet or on the Vientiane plain closes its market: no more trading there.
- **A fight in the dark.** Under the Travel by Night law, a fight in the season the party travelled is fought in the dark: the soldiers' number and the party's ATK are both 1 lower.
- **A carried child.** When the party travels, an adult with a free hand carries a child on their back (see Clans, fields and caches): in a fight that season the carrier has one hand, ATK −1, and the child cannot be hit.
- **The quick fight** (optional, for experienced tables). One clash decides the whole fight: the party deals double, the soldiers deal their number once; a win is a win, anything else is a stalemate with your wounds. Faster, not safer.
- **Who the soldiers are.** To the end of 1976 the patrols are Pathet Lao and village militia; from 1977 the Lao People's Army and Vietnamese units, with artillery on the mountain. The Patrol card names them on each face, and each grade carries a mark (I, II, III, IIII, a wave for the river) as well as its colour.

3 · Count the cost

Win, and the party **searches this place in safety**: 1 card for Easy, 2 for Medium, 3 for Hard, skipping Danger, Nothing and key cards. Damage a survivor took becomes wounds. A fight the party only survived (three clashes and the soldiers still stand) gives nothing.



A worked example

Fall 1976. Chai, Mai, Chao and Blong are in the Phou Khao Khouay Jungle. Their stats add up to 6 HP, 12 ATK and 14 DEF. Mai searches and draws a **Hard** danger. The Hard row, the column for 4, the 1975 block: the soldiers are **9**: 9 HP, 9 ATK and 9 DEF.

Clash 1. The Fortune card is a 12: an even clash. The party deals $12 - 9 = 3$; the soldiers have 6 left. The soldiers deal $9 - 14$, nothing, but always at least 1. Blong, who wears the Helmet (Armor 1), stands in front, and the Helmet stops it. **Clash 2.** The Fortune card is a 3: the soldiers' aim is true, 11 ATK this clash, still nothing through 14 DEF, so 1 again, and this time Blong takes a wound. The party deals 3 more; the soldiers have 3 left. **Clash 3.** An 18: the villagers find their mark, 14 ATK this clash, $14 - 9 = 5$, and the soldiers fall. Chai takes the last wound. The family then searches the jungle **three times in safety**: Herbs, a Guide and Rice.

Had this been an ambush, the soldiers would have fired first and the party would have dealt nothing in clash 1: after three clashes the soldiers would still stand, and the family would break away with its wounds and nothing to show.

The story cloth, keys and clues

The way out is a story cloth (*paj ntaub dab neeg*) of **nine squares**, laid out 3 × 3 on the cloth mat. Story cloths were first stitched in the Thai refugee camps by families who had made this crossing, to record the war and the flight. Each square shows one stage of the escape, in order: read its story aloud from the Companion when it is recovered. You need **all nine**, whatever the size of your party.



1. The Village 1961 to 1975 · Before



2. The Last Planes May 1975 · Left behind



3. The Soldiers Come 1975 onward · The new government



4. Into the Forest 1975 to 1976 · Phou Bia



5. Hiding 1975 to 1980 · In the jungle



6. Fire from the Sky 1977 to 1978 · The offensives



7. The Walk South 1975 to 1980 · The way out



8. The Crossing 1975 to 1992 · The Mekong



9. The Camp 1975 to 1992 · Ban Vinai

Keys

The squares not sewn at the start are won with **keys** hidden in the search decks (a letter from Nong Khai, signal fires on the ridge, a patrol timetable, a fisherman's signal). Keys are scarce near home and plentiful near the river: **1** in the village, **1** in each Hills place, **2** in each Jungle place, **4** in each Lowlands place and **3** in each River place (37 in all). Each key you win recovers the next missing square, and the living villager carrying the fewest squares takes it: put the square on the mat and note who carries it.

Key encounters

No square comes free. Each key card names what stands between you and it, and the danger is always **one step harder** than that place's own Danger card: easy becomes medium, medium becomes hard, hard becomes **deadly** (the Deadly row of the Patrol table). Choose one:

- **Guarded:** Fight for it one step harder than this place. Win and the piece is yours. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass gets close first: no step up. Or leave it for now.
- **A Price:** Pay with a silver item, baht or coins, or 2 Food (an offering item for a shaman). Or take it by force: a fight one step harder. Or walk away.
- **On the Fallen:** Take it now, then his comrades ambush you at this place's level. An evade card, Tou or Gao can still get you away. Or leave it.
- **Mined:** Take it now, then everyone draws a Fortune card: on 1 to 4, 2 wounds (a Dog sniffs out the mines: only on a 1). Or leave it.
- **Wait for Dark:** Take it now, but everyone eats 1 Food while you wait, and on a Fortune card of 1 to 8 a patrol finds you: a fight one step harder. Or leave it.
- Or **leave it for now**: put it at the bottom of that place's search deck and a **Guard token** on the tile, so the table sees where its keys wait. You can find it again.

Two **disguise pieces** in the party (Lao Clothes, a Forged Travel Pass, a Lao Identity Card, the Translator) get you close enough that a Guarded or Price key is not stepped up.

Key fights give no spoils (the square is the prize), and spoils searches after other fights skip keys.

When a carrier falls

If a villager carrying squares is **killed by soldiers, a mine or a bomb, or taken prisoner**, their squares lie where they fell: shuffle each into the top 3 cards of that place's search deck as a **fallen square** (an "On the Fallen" key encounter: the soldiers are still near). Winning it puts that same square back on the cloth, and so does **any other key** you win later: the fallen square is just the nearest way back, and a fallen square already replaced is spent when it is drawn. A villager who dies among the family, of **hunger, sickness or the cold**, hands their squares on: the living villager carrying the fewest takes them. Squares are never lost at the river or in the fight with the River Patrol, and a villager who surrenders hands theirs on.

Clues

Four kinds of clue card are shuffled into the search decks. **A Safe Crossing Place** and **A Boatman** stay with the tile they were found on and help a crossing from there. **A Guide** stays with the party: every Danger draw when the party moves is 3 better. **A Trail Map** turns face up every tile in the next row at once.

Omens and the Turning Point

Omen cards from the Season deck go on the **Omen row** of the board, one in each slot from the left. Each time one arrives, draw a Fortune card: on the number printed under its slot or less (5, 10, 15, then 20: the fourth omen is certain), the **Turning Point** comes. Shuffle the six Turning Point cards and draw one; it lasts for the rest of the game. Only one Turning Point happens in a game. It comes in about half of all games, at a different time each game.

The river



Crossing the Mekong at night.

With all nine squares on the cloth, the party may **Cross** (1 action, from any river place). A **Safe Crossing Place** on that tile helps every check; a **Boatman** there sells boat seats for silver. The crossing has three parts: the River Patrol on the bank, the boats and rafts, and the water.

1 · The River Patrol

Lao and Vietnamese soldiers hold the crossing with a machine gun and a boat. They are the hardest fight in the game: read the **River Patrol row** of the Patrol table (it counts at most 5 people). Escape cards and ambushes do not apply here; the Fortune card is drawn each clash as usual, and they always wound at least 1. Fight up to **3 clashes**. Beat them and you reach the water unseen. If they still stand after 3 clashes, or neither side can hurt the other, the party **breaks for the water under fire**: the Boatman will not come, but a canoe you found yourselves can still be launched. If the patrol kills everyone, the game ends at the river.

2 · Boats and rafts

A Dugout Canoe carries 2. With a Boatman (not under fire), each money item (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht, a ball of opium) buys one seat, and the boat takes **four a trip**: a party of five or six crosses in two trips, and the second trip meets the River Patrol again. Everyone else goes on a raft: free with Raft Poles or Driftwood, otherwise give up any 2 items. With no raft, they swim. Animals stay on the bank.

Non-swimmers. Most highland villagers could not swim; only Pao and Sheng can (the mark on the card). A non-swimmer who is swept away is drowned **2 worse**, unless they hold a **float** item (Bamboo Float Tubes, a Truck Inner Tube, Rattan Rope). **Pairs.** Two

villagers may walk the lane as a pair on one set of draws, and a child is always paired with an adult; if the pair is swept away, both are. **Low water.** In Spring, outside the monsoon, the current check is 2 better.

3 · The water

Each person, children and the sick first, walks the **Mekong lane** along the bottom of the board, station by station, with up to three Fortune draws, in order; stand their standee on each station as they reach it:

1. **Down to the water.** On 3 or less (7 or less under fire) the person is hit: on the lowest quarter of that range (1, or 1–2 under fire) they are killed at the water's edge; otherwise they go on wounded. A Safe Crossing Place, the Travel by Night law and Gao's Quiet Hands (Side B) each make this 1–2 better.
2. **The current: draw a River card.** Shuffle the River deck (add the 3 monsoon cards in Summer or Fall) and draw one for this person. Read it aloud and, if it offers a choice, decide together. Most cards end in the **current check**, changed by the card: swept away on the number in the table or less; above it, the person reaches Thailand. Some carry you straight across, some cost what you carry, and some put you straight into the water. If the deck runs out, shuffle the drawn cards.
3. **Swept away.** Anyone the current takes draws again: drowned on **12 or less**, +3 in the monsoon, +2 for a child, elder, sick or wounded person, +2 for a non-swimmer without a float, 2 better if someone is already on the Thai bank to throw a line, 2 better for anyone who was on a raft or boat (they cling to the bamboo or the hull), and better with floats. Above it, they crawl out on the Thai bank. On **18 or more** the river itself is merciful: they are carried far downstream and **washed up** alone on the Thai bank, alive and with nothing (Ending 1).

THE CURRENT CHECK	SWEPT AWAY ON
Base (most highland villagers could not swim)	13
Monsoon: Summer or Fall	+4
Child, elder, sick or wounded (a bullet at the water counts)	+2
In a boat	−6
On a raft	−3
At a Safe Crossing Place	−3
The holder of an Inner Tube (−3), Bamboo Floats (−2) or Rattan Rope (−1)	up to −4

Hope at the river. If the current or the water takes someone, you may spend **1 Hope** to draw that check again, once per person. A family that has held on to its spirit has a better chance at the end.

The tributary. Between the lowlands and the river row runs a stream. Travelling across it in Summer or Fall, when it is in flood, draw a Fortune card: on 1 or 2 the heaviest-laden villager loses an item to the water.

For example

Winter 1977, the Ferry Crossing, all nine squares. The party of four beats the River Patrol in two clashes. Pao (a swimmer) and Chao (a child) cross as a pair on Pao's draws: a River card, *Slack Water*, then a 9 against a current check of 13 − 3 for the Safe Crossing Place = 10: swept away. Pao draws for the drowning check: 15, above 12, and both crawl out. Mai, no swimmer, holding the Inner Tube, draws 16 against 13: across. Chai, no swimmer and no float, draws 4: swept away; the drowning check is 14 or less for him, he draws 13, and spends 1 Hope to draw again: 19 washes him up far downstream, alone, alive.

The River deck is listed in full in the Companion.

AFTER THE GAME

The end of the game



Across the river: a camp in Thailand at dawn.

The game ends the moment someone reaches the Thai bank and no one is left in the water, when the last villager dies or is taken, or at the end of Winter 1979. Then, in this order:

1. **The ending card.** Read **Ending A, Across the Mekong** if anyone crossed, or **Ending B, The ones who stayed** if no one did. Say aloud the names of those who did not reach the river. The full texts are in the Companion.
2. **What really happened.** Read the short history in date order (Companion). Disputed claims say so.
3. **A Voice.** Shuffle the Voice cards of that ending (blue for A, green for B), draw one and read it aloud. Each is built from the recollection of a real person, retold in the game's words.
4. **Each villager's life.** For every villager, find what became of them in the **Endings booklet**. An ending is the villager's name and a number, the same numbers for every villager and for both sides of the card: 1 to 2 crossed the Mekong (draw a Fortune card: 1 to 10 reads 1, 11 to 20 reads 2), 3 still in Laos, 4 taken prisoner, 5 killed by soldiers, 6 starved, 7 died of sickness, 8 a bomb or a mine, 9 drowned, 10 shot trying to cross. The booklet's first chapter has the table and a family record to fill in during the game.
5. **What we carried.** Each player names one thing their villager carried the whole way, and writes it on the family record.
6. **The dedication**, on the cover of this book.

The Late Crossing. If the game ended with the family still in Laos, it can go on: the scenario card starts the survivors in Spring 1979 at a lowlands place with the

squares they held, the From 1977 face of the Patrol table and the Pushed Back river card in the deck, and gives them until the end of 1980.

The stories are invented, but each is built from the real accounts of families who made this journey.

REFERENCE

The villagers

Each power breaks a rule rather than adding a point. **Side A** powers are used **once a season** (Winter Clothes once a year): an **action** takes one of that villager's actions, a **free action** costs none, and a **reaction** is used when its moment comes, on anyone's turn. **Side B** traits are always on. Both sides of a card have the same HP, ATK and DEF, so the choice is how you want to play. Children (Chao, Gao) and elders (Blong, Tou) count as such for the Toll and at the river.

Under each name the card gives the villager's **clan** and their **family**: Blong is Chai's father, Chai and Mai are married, Chao and Gao are their children, all of the Hang clan; the others walk with them from the same village. Clan kinship obliged a Hmong family to shelter and feed a clansman on the road, even one never met, and the Strangers you meet remember it (see Clans, fields and caches). The **cannot swim** mark is on every card but Pao's and Sheng's.



Chai MAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ▰▰▱▱▱

A · Senglao (Mayor). *Rally the Village* (free action, once a season). Once per season, free (it costs Chai no action), while Hope is 3 or more and not in Winter: one villager who has not acted yet this season takes 1 extra action.

B · Senglao in exile. *Keeps the Council* (always on). The council is offered 3 laws each Winter instead of 2, and every law it adopts gives Hope +1. Every Winter, if Hope is 1 or 0, Hope +1.

Own items: Soul Lock, Silver Bar



Tou MAN

HP ●●●○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ▰▰▱▱▱

A · Teacher. *Talk Our Way Past* (reaction, when its moment comes). Once per season, when soldiers find the party (not the River Patrol), Tou speaks to them in Lao: draw a Fortune card, on 7 or more there is no fight.

B · Teacher who reads Thai and Lao. *Reads the Signs* (always on). Tou's own searches look at 6 cards and keep 1 (the rest go to the bottom). The first search each season by anyone else looks at 2 and keeps 1.

Own items: Book, Translator



Mai WOMAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ▰▱▱▱▱

A · Farmer. *Hidden Harvest* (an action, once a season). Once per season, as an action, where anything grows this season: +4 Food, and no one sees her.

B · Rice farmer, widow. *Every Grain* (always on). Mai's Forage finds 3 more Food wherever anything grows.

Own items: Hoe, Knife



Chao MAN

HP ●○○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ▰▰▰▱▱

A · Kid. *Runner* (free action, once a season). Once per season, as an action that eats no Food: Chao runs ahead and reveals 1 hidden place next to the party, the one farthest ahead.

B · Kid, message runner. *Lookout* (always on). The party is never ambushed: when soldiers find you or catch you foraging, you shoot back from the first clash.

Own items: Slingshot, Tub Luj



Gao WOMAN

HP ●○○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊▽▽▽

A · Kid. *Hush* (reaction, when its moment comes). Once per season, when a noise or foraging draw would bring soldiers, Gao keeps everyone silent in the leaves: the soldiers pass by.

B · Kid, little mother. *Quiet Hands* (always on). Gao is never spotted while foraging, and her searches make no noise. Everyone else's noise is 2 lower.

Own items: Doll, Rocks



Sheng WOMAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ⛊▽▽▽▽

A · Hunter. *The Hunt* (an action, once a season). Once per season, free (it costs Sheng no action; not in Winter): draw a Fortune card. On 6 or more, +4 Food. On 5 or less the shot is heard: an Easy fight.

B · Crossbow hunter. *Fresh Meat* (always on). Sheng's Forage finds 2 more Food wherever anything grows: snares, birds, fish traps. While Sheng holds a quiet weapon (bow, crossbow, spear, slingshot) the party fires first in every fight.

Own items: Bow, Hmong Gun



Chong MAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛊▽▽

A · Blacksmith. *Bamboo Armor* (free action, once a season). Once per season, as an action: make a Bamboo Armor (body, Armor 1) for a villager with a free body slot. It falls apart after it has stopped 2 bullets.

B · Raft builder. *Builder* (always on). A camp Chong builds is finished in one action, and at the river the party's raft is free.

Own items: Hammer, Sharpening Stone, Bamboo Armor



Meng MAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊▽▽▽

A · Shaman. *Spirits Are Here* (an action, once a season). Once per season, as an action: look at the top 3 cards of this place, put any Danger or Nothing cards on the bottom, then search here once with no noise.

B · Shaman who reads the bones. *Reads the Bones* (always on). Twice a year, when a Season card is drawn, Meng may put it on the bottom of the deck and draw another.

Own items: Cloth Mask, Chu Neej



Pao MAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛊▽▽

A · Farmer. *River Man* (an action, once a season). Once per season, as an action, where there is water (stream, bamboo, caves, jungle, fields, Lao village, riverbank, hamlet, ferry): +4 Food. At the river, one child, elder, sick or wounded villager crosses with him: 3 better on the current.

B · Fisherman-farmer, strong swimmer. *Strong Swimmer* (always on). Pao's current draw is 2 better, and anyone swept away after Pao is across is pulled out 2 better. Forage where there is water finds 2 more Food.

Own items: Scythe, Carrying Basket (Kwb)



Blong MAN

HP ●○○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛊▽▽

A · Elder. *The Old Road* (reaction, when its moment comes). Once per season, when the party Travels, Blong leads them by an old path: no Danger draw, and they gather 1 more Food on the way.

B · Elder who knows the old roads. *Knows the Hills* (always on). Every Danger draw when the party Travels is 2 better.

Own items: Cane, Ring



Cheng MAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◆◇◇ DEF ⛊⛉⛉⛉⛉

A · Soldier. *Ready for Battle* (reaction, when its moment comes). Once per season, when a fight starts (not the River Patrol): the party has +2 ATK for that fight.

B · SGU radio operator. *Return Fire* (always on). When the party is ambushed, it still shoots back in the first clash.

Own items: M-16, Hmong Knife



Kong MAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛉⛉⛉

A · Doctor. *Field Surgery* (reaction, when its moment comes). Once per season, after a fight: the most wounded survivor heals 1 wound on the spot.

B · Medic trained at Sam Thong. *Field Medic* (always on). Every Rest heals 1 more wound, and when Kong nurses the Sick, the fever always breaks.

Own items: Medicine Box, Scalpel



Lee WOMAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛉⛉⛉

A · Medicine Woman. *Fever Bark* (free action, once a season). Once per season, free (it costs Lee no action): cure one Sick villager and make a Healing Salve (HP +3, next fight).

B · Herbalist. *Wild Greens* (always on). Lee's Forage finds 1 more Food wherever anything grows, every Rest heals 1 more wound, and when Lee nurses someone Sick the fever always breaks.

Own items: Herbs, Bandages



Bao WOMAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛊⛉⛉

A · Tailor. *Winter Clothes* (free action, once a year). Once a year, free, in Fall or Winter: everyone draws 6 better at this Winter's Toll.

B · Tailor of warm clothes. *Warm Clothes* (always on). Everyone's Winter Toll is 3 better.

Own items: Needles, Paj Ntaub



Ka WOMAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◇◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛊⛉⛉

A · Singer. *Sing at Night* (free action, once a season). Once per season, free (it costs Ka no action): Ka sings kwv txhiaj by the fire. Hope +1, and the most wounded villager heals 1.

B · Kwv txhiaj singer. *Songs at Night* (always on). Hope never falls below 2, and at the start of every Winter her New Year songs give Hope +1.

Own items: Qeej, Tsaaj Nplaim



Pa WOMAN

HP ●●○○○ ATK ◆◆◇◇◇ DEF ⛊⛊⛉⛉⛉

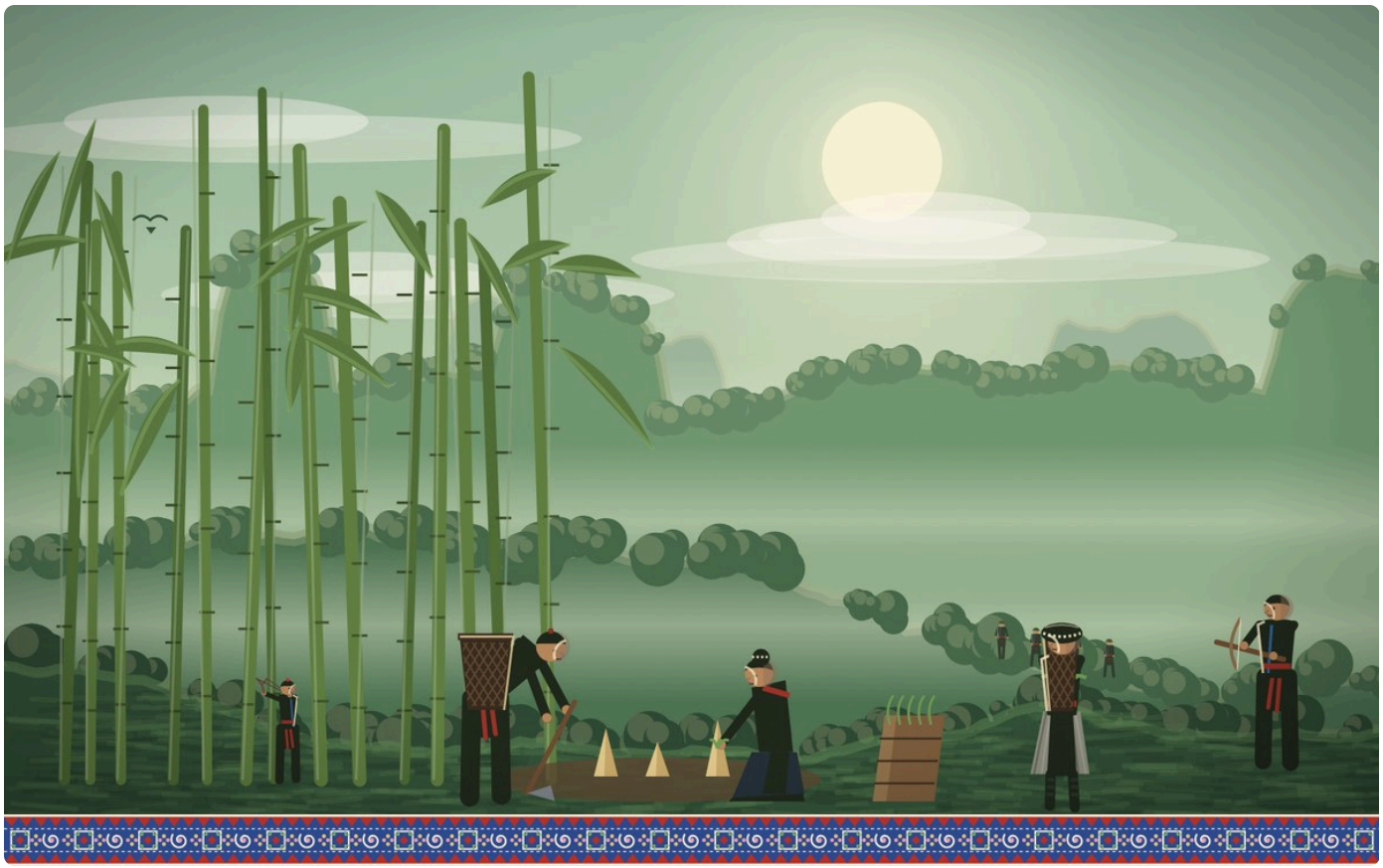
A · Shaman. *Call the Soul Back* (reaction, when its moment comes). Once a year, when a villager would die in a fight, Pa calls their soul back: they live with 1 HP.

B · Shaman, soul caller. *Calls the Soul Home* (always on). A death costs no Hope: Pa leads the rites. A fever Pa nurses always breaks. Once a game, the first villager the Toll would take is spared (hu plig). Winter at Hope 0 or 1: Hope +1. Once a year she reads the bones: put a drawn Season card under the deck, draw another.

Own items: Joss Paper, Incense Sticks

PLAYING ALONE

Solo rules



Alone on the trail.

Chao Fa plays well alone. One player runs a whole family, usually **four villagers** (Chai, Mai, Chao and Blong make a good first party; the app's Learn to play uses them), and everything in this book applies. These few rules make the solo game fair and keep its story.

1. **The party.** Take 3 or 4 villagers. Choose a side for each as usual. Four is the recommended size: three is harder, and five or six gives you too much to remember.
2. **Decisions.** Dilemmas, strangers and the council are yours to decide, but decide them **in character**: ask what this family would do, not what the odds say. Read the card aloud, even alone. That is how the game works.
3. **Fallen villagers.** The extra action for a fallen player's table-mates does not apply; when one of your villagers dies, the party simply has one person fewer.
4. **Hidden information.** Keep the search decks face down and never peek. The Fortune deck is shuffled when it runs out, not before.
5. **The diary.** Keep a sheet beside the board and write one line at the end of each season: where the family is, who is hurt, what they chose. When the game ends, read the diary with the Ending and the Voice card. It is the solo player's story cloth.
6. **Difficulty.** Play Brutal. A solo party of 4 crosses about as often as a table of four, because the engine's test player is a single mind too. If the first games end in the hills, play the Short Trail or Historical once, then return.

The app has a solo mode built in: start a game with 3 or 4 villagers and the same rules apply, with the diary kept for you in the log.

REFERENCE

Difficulty levels

The rules in this book are the **Brutal** level, the way the game is meant to be played. To learn the game, or for a gentler evening, add or take away from every soldier number and change a few numbers as the table says. Whatever the level, a thoughtful table that plans its route, feeds its people and knows when to run does better than one that fights everything.

LEVEL	WHAT CHANGES	WHO GETS ACROSS
Gentle	Every Patrol table number 3 lower, and the River Patrol row 3 lower again. For learning: no noise, no ambushes or prisoners, no carry slots; river 11, Toll 3, fever 1–3, spotted on 1–2.	Most cross
Historical	The Patrol table as written, with the earlier, milder rules: no carry slots; the River Patrol row 3 lower, river 11, Toll 3, fever 1–3, spotted on 1–2.	Many cross
Brutal	These rules, as written in this book. The recommended way to play.	Few cross
Merciless	Brutal, with 3 added to every soldier number.	Almost no one crosses
The Short Trail	12 seasons (Spring 1975 to Winter 1977) instead of 20, the first 3 squares of the story cloth already sewn (on top of any head start), and 5 Food each to start. Everything else is Brutal. About an hour.	Few cross

REFERENCE

Hmong words in the game

The cards use a few Hmong words, written in the Romanized Popular Alphabet (RPA) that Hmong communities have used since the 1950s. In RPA a **final consonant is not sounded: it marks the tone**. *Hmoob* is said "Hmong", *paj ntaub* "pa ndau", *qeej* "gheng", *hmoov* "hmong" with a rising tone. The tone letters are **-b** high, **-j** high falling, **-v** mid rising, **-s** low, **-g** low breathy, **-m** low creaky, **-d** rising creaky, and no letter for the mid tone. Doubled vowels (*oo*, *ee*) are nasal. Say them as best you can; the people in this game would be glad you tried.

Hmoob Hmong; the people and the language.

Cob Fab Chao Fa, "Lords of the Sky": the Hmong resistance after 1975.

paj ntaub "flower cloth": Hmong embroidery and appliqué.

paj ntaub dab neeg a story cloth, stitched in the refugee camps to record the war and the flight.

hmoov fortune, luck; the name of the Fortune deck.

ntuj the sky, heaven; also the world or the weather (*Ntuj pab*, heaven helps).

dab a spirit; *dab phem*, an ill spirit.

plig the soul; a *hu plig* calls a wandering soul home.

txiv neeb a shaman, who heals by travelling to the spirit world (the Stranger card).

qeej the Hmong reed pipe, played at funerals to guide the soul home.

xauv the silver neck ring, locking the soul in the body (the Soul Lock item).

tub rog a soldier (*tub*, a young man; *rog*, war).

zos a village.

tsev a house, a home; *nco tsev*, homesick.

hav zoov the forest, the jungle.

roob a mountain; the Hmong were the people of the high ridges.

mov cooked rice; *noj mov*, to eat, a meal.

siab the heart (literally the liver): *siab tawv*, brave; *ua siab ntev*, be patient.

nyob zoo hello (literally "stay well").

ua tsaug thank you.

niam, txiv mother, father; *me nyuam*, a child; *yawg*, grandfather.

kev a path, a way (*pom kev*, to see the way); also "the matter of", as in *kev khwv*, hard work.

Spellings follow Heimbach's *White Hmong Dictionary* and the Hmong Dictionary at hmongdictionary.com. The game's names

(Chai, Mai, Chao, Blong, Tou, Gao, Kong, Lee, Pa) are the English spellings Hmong families use, as on a passport, not RPA.

REFERENCE

Icon key and glossary

Icons


Search
draw from this place's deck


Scout
turn a next tile face up


Travel
the whole party moves


Food
to the store


Rest or nurse
heal, or break a fever


Camp
a finished hidden camp


Easy fight
the Easy row


Medium fight
the Medium row


Hard fight
the Hard row


Ambush
they fire first


Escape card
discard: no fight


Shelter
+DEF in the next fight


Remedy
+HP in the next fight


Key
a key encounter; win a square


Story cloth
squares sewn


Clue
stays with the tile or the party


Dilemma
the party decides


Stranger
Seek help


Omen
keep face up; draw for the Turning Point


Turning Point
for the rest of the game


Law
adopted at the council


Sick
1 action; nurse or draw for fever


Wound
−1 HP


Hope
0 to 6


Winter
eat, the Toll, the council


Nothing
no effect

Item slots


Both hands


One hand


Body


Head


Pack


Shared by the party

Glossary

Action One of a villager's 2 per season (1 if Sick). Travel is taken by the whole party instead.

Ambush A fight where the soldiers fire first: being found, spotted, or an Ambush card.

Armor Stops that much damage to its wearer in each fight.

Clash One exchange in a fight; up to three.

Danger number On the tile: Travel there is a fight on a Fortune card of that or less.

Escape card Discard it when soldiers find you: no fight (never the River Patrol).

Fallen square A square dropped where its carrier was killed by soldiers, a mine or a bomb, or taken prisoner, shuffled into the top 3 cards there. Win it back there, or fill the gap with any other key. A death of hunger, sickness or cold hands the square on.

Fever An unnursed Sick villager dies on a Fortune card of 1 to 5 at the end of the season.

Fight tracker The tall card that holds a fight: the soldiers' number, the three clashes, the damage dealt.

Fortune card One of 20 cards, 1 to 20, drawn wherever the game asks for a check; in a fight, 1–4 helps the soldiers and 17–20 the party.

Found item An item nobody owns; its effect is printed on the card.

Free action A power that costs no action.

Grade How hard a fight is: Easy, Medium, Hard or Deadly, a row of the Patrol table.

Hungry Went short at the last Winter meal.

Key A guarded card that recovers the next square when won.

Legendary item Works the same for everyone and has a power.

Noise Searching a place again: soldiers come on a Fortune card of earlier searches or less.

Patrol table The soldiers' number (ATK, DEF and HP alike) by the fight, the living villagers and the year.

Own item An item with a villager's name: the larger bonus for them.

Party All living villagers; they always move together.

Phase marker Walks down the season track on the board: card, Travel, actions, Winter, time.

Reaction A power used when its moment comes, on anyone's turn.

Safe search A free search that skips Danger, Nothing and key cards.

Sick Acts once; nurse each season or draw for fever; dies if the Toll takes them again.

Spoils Safe searches after a won fight: 1, 2 or 3 by grade.

The Toll The Winter sickness draw: Sick on a Fortune card of 5 or less, adjusted.

Turning Point One card that changes the rest of the game, when the omens come true.

Under fire Breaking for the water with the River Patrol still standing.

X The number of villagers at the start.

Alarm A token left by a fight with loud weapons: the next fight there is one row harder.

Break away Drop one item per living villager after clash 1 or 2 and end the fight.

Cache Items left on a tile; picked up when the party returns.

Clan The villager's wider family, under the name on the card; a Stranger of the same clan helps for nothing.

Disguise piece Lao Clothes, a Forged Travel Pass, a Lao Identity Card, the Translator: two together get you close.

Float A Bamboo Float Tube, Inner Tube or Rattan Rope: better in the current, and a non-swimmer's only help.

Guard token Marks a tile where a key encounter was left.

Hidden field Planted in Spring for 1 Food; +4 Food in Fall if the party is still there and no fight has happened.

Loud weapon Any firearm; its shots raise the alarm.

Money Silver, coins, baht, opium: pays a Boatman, a Price, a Trade or a shakedown.

Non-swimmer Every villager but Pao and Sheng: drowned 2 worse without a float.

Omen row Five slots on the board; the number under the newest Omen is the Turning Point draw.

Pair Two villagers crossing on one set of draws; a child is always paired.

Picked clean A tile turned back over when its deck is used up: no forage, no search, Danger 1 better.

Quiet weapon A bow, crossbow, knife or spear: no alarm; a hunter fires first.

Shakedown Buying off an Easy fight with 2 Food or a money item.

Washed up Swept away and drawing 18 or more: alone on the Thai bank with nothing.

dab A spirit; dab phem, an ill spirit (Fortune card 1).

plig The soul; a Soul Lock keeps it with the body.

txiv neeb A shaman, who crosses into the spirit world to call a soul back.

ua neeb A shaman's ceremony.

hmoov Fortune, luck: the name of the Fortune deck.

qeej The bamboo mouth organ played at funerals, so the soul finds its way home.

REFERENCE

Questions players ask

Can we split up? Can one villager scout ahead while the others search?

No. The party always moves together; Travel moves everyone. Only Chao's Runner power (Side A) reveals a place from a distance, and he comes back.

We searched the village three times. Do we still draw for noise on the fourth search, and what is the number?

Yes. Draw a Fortune card before the search: on 3 or less (the number of earlier searches there), soldiers come and you fight at the village's level, with no spoils; then you search. Cover tracks counts 2 fewer earlier searches; Gao on Side B makes everyone else's noise 2 lower.

Does Travel cost an action?

It costs the whole season. Travel only before anyone has taken an action this season; the party moves, gathers the tile's forage, eats 1 Food for the journey, and the season ends. In Winter the end-of-season steps still happen after you arrive.

Who pays the Food for a Search when the store is empty?

Nobody; the searcher takes a wound instead (unless that wound would kill them). The search still happens.

A villager has 3 HP and 3 wounds. Are they dead?

Yes. Wounds are −1 HP each; at 0 the villager dies. Each Spring everyone who ate heals 1, and resting heals 1 (2 at a finished camp).

Does the party eat every season?

Only in Winter (1 Food each). The rest of the year you eat by working: Search, Scout, Build and Travel each cost 1 Food, and foraging brings Food in.

How many soldiers do we face? Walk me through it.

Find the row for the fight (Easy, Medium, Hard, Deadly or the River Patrol), the column for how many of you are living, and the block for the year. That one number is their ATK, DEF and HP. Nothing is added: an ambush only means they fire first, and the only thing that changes a clash is the Fortune card.

The soldiers' ATK is lower than our DEF. Do we take damage?

Yes, a little: gunfire gets through. Each clash the party takes at least 1 wound, however high its DEF. Armor can stop it.

Can we choose not to fight when a Danger card comes up?

Only with an escape card (discard it: no fight), Tou's talk (Side A, Fortune card of 7 or more) or Gao's hush (Side A, for noise or a spotting). Otherwise the fight happens.

When is a fallen villager a prisoner?

When they fall in a fight, not in the river, they draw a Fortune card: 1 to 10 they were killed, 11 to 20 they are taken prisoner. Either way they leave the game; the ending differs (5 or 4).

We used a crossbow and a rifle. Is there an alarm?

Yes. One loud weapon in the fight is enough. Only a party that fought with quiet weapons alone leaves no Alarm token.

Can we pick up a cache with a different villager?

Yes. Anyone in the party with room takes what is in the cache when the party is on that tile again.

What happens to a prisoner's items and squares?

Items are lost with them. Squares of the story cloth drop where they fell: shuffle each into the top 3 cards of that place's search deck as a fallen square, and win it back with an On the Fallen key encounter, or fill the gap with any other key you find.

A carrier starves in Winter. Do their squares drop?

No. Only a carrier killed by soldiers, a mine or a bomb, or taken prisoner, drops their squares where they fell. A villager who dies among the family, of hunger, sickness or the cold, hands them on to the living villager carrying the fewest.

Do we need nine squares even with three villagers?

Yes, always nine. A party of 3 starts with squares 1 to 5 already sewn, 4 with 1 to 4, 5 with 1 to 3, 6 with 1

and 2. Word From Thailand (a Turning Point) lowers the need by one.

Can we leave a key and come back for it?

Yes. Put it at the bottom of that place's search deck. You can find it again by searching the deck down.

A key encounter in a Hard place: how hard is Deadly?

The Deadly row: a party of 4 in 1978 faces 17 HP, ATK and DEF. Someone in Lao Clothes or with a Forged Travel Pass avoids the step up on a Guarded key.

When does the Toll happen, and who draws?

At the end of each Winter, after everyone has eaten. Every living villager draws a Fortune card and is Sick on 5 or less, adjusted for age, hunger, the cold of the year, Hope, a healer, a camp and warm items. Someone already Sick who fails it dies.

How does a Sick villager get better?

Someone nurses them (an action): the fever breaks on a Fortune card of 11 or more, 6 or more with medicine in the party, always with Kong on Side B in the party or with Lee or Pa on Side B nursing. Unnursed, they draw for fever at the end of the season and die on 1 to 5.

Can we adopt more than one law?

One per council, so at most five in a game (the council meets each Winter). Laws stay for the rest of the game and cannot be undone.

We have the cloth and we are on the riverbank in Summer. Should we wait for Winter?

The monsoon makes every current check 4 worse and adds three flood cards, so many families wait. But every season waited is a season the army grows stronger and the Toll comes closer. That is the game.

How many boat seats does the Boatman give?

One per silver item you hand over (Silver Bar, Ring, Soul Lock, French Silver Coins, Thai Baht), and only if the River Patrol was beaten: under fire the Boatman will not come. A Dugout Canoe you found carries 2 whatever happens.

Someone was swept away. Can we save them?

They draw the drowning check: lost on 12 or less (14 for a non-swimmer without a float), washed up alive on 18 or more, worse in the monsoon and for the young, old, sick and wounded, better with a line from the Thai bank, a raft or boat to cling to, or floats. Before that, you may spend 1 Hope to draw again the check that took them, once per person.

The time marker reached season 20 and the Winter ended. We are on the riverbank with eight squares.

The game ends: Ending B. Read it, a Voice card, and what became of each villager who is still alive in Laos.

How long does a game take?

Sixty to a hundred and twenty minutes for a full Trail of 20 seasons; about an hour for the Short Trail. Most games end before season 20.

REFERENCE

Did you forget?

Read this page aloud before the second game. Every line is a rule tables forget.

1. Every search after the first in a place draws a Fortune card for noise before the search card.
2. The party eats only in Winter, but Search, Scout, Travel and Build a Camp each eat 1 Food.
3. Armor stops the first hit to its wearer in each fight, then the wounds start.
4. An ambush means only that the soldiers fire first. Nothing is added to their number.
5. The soldiers' number is read once from the Patrol table and never changes during the fight.
6. The Fortune deck is reshuffled only when it runs out, never at the end of a season.
7. A villager taken prisoner loses everything they carried. A villager who dies of hunger, sickness or cold hands their squares on.
8. A child cannot cross alone: pair them with an adult, who draws for both.
9. A Stranger of your clan helps for nothing. A key encounter left for later gets a Guard token.
10. Loud shots leave an Alarm token: the next fight at that place is one row harder.
11. Only Pao and Sheng can swim. Everyone else wants a float before the river.
12. The Omen row decides the Turning Point draw: 5, 10, 15, then certain.

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